

Facts and Possibilities

Is Rizal Really Still Alive?

I met my first Rizalista during a field trip to the Rizal shrine in Fort Santiago in my fourth grade. He was an old man standing by the Rizal cell, and what made him look strange were the *anting-antings* hung around his neck and, pinned to his shirt, a "photo" of God the Father with an arm around Rizal.

When he noticed us peering into the dark cell where Rizal was imprisoned before his execution, he turned to us and asked. "*Bakit may bentilador diyan sa loob?*" Noticing the obvious anachronism myself, I answered, "*Ewan ko*, there were no electric fans in Rizal's time, right?" One of my classmates, the typical Atenean *pilosopo-brat* said, "*Baka naiinitan.*" The man did not get mad at the wisecrack; in fact, he complimented my classmate by asking again, "*Bakit naiinitan?*" To which another classmate said, "*Naka-amerikana kasi, eh!*"

At this, the man seemed to lose his composure and told us that Rizal was, indeed, alive and well in Mount Banahaw and that he would come in glory after the end of the world, which would see seven suns rising over the Philippines.

After the fire-and-brimstone sermon, he started to sing to the wax statue inside the cell, an act that attracted even more people. At that point, we were embarrassed and left him. I have never forgotten that day and since then, I had always defended from some narrow-minded Catholics the *colorums'* right to worship Rizal. One day, early this year, I stumbled upon an interesting document in the National Archives in Manila that could give the Rizalistas proof for their case that Rizal is divine, alive and well, and shuttling from one holy mountain to another namely Mt. Arayat, Mt. Makiling, and Mt. Banahaw.

On March 29, 1897, three months after Rizal's execution, the Spanish governor-general received a report from one of his agents:

The natives in some districts such as Pandacan, San Juan del Monte, San Felipe Nery in this capital believe in the rumors circulating that Jose Rizal, executed last 29 December *[sic]* in Bagumbayan, is not dead as stated in the papers but, on the contrary, is alive and well because of a miracle.

After the execution of Rizal, the body was wrapped and loaded into a carriage which was enveloped by a rose-colored cloud, which followed the carriage all the way to the cemetery where, upon reaching the gates, the soldiers discovered that Rizal's body had disappeared and in its place was a beautiful white cock which then flew in the direction of Cavite to join the soul of Fr. Burgos, executed in 1872, who was alive and hiding in that province... the natives also believe that the corpse of Rizal transfers itself miraculously from place to place within the [Paco] cemetery!

One of the comments of the agent was that the Filipino rebels were using both Rizal's name and these rumors to recruit people into joining the revolution against Spain. He pointed to the Rizal family as partly responsible for encouraging this cult. Historians cannot write a history based on a stray document filled with rumors, but this document in the National Archives proves that the Rizalista cult was not cooked up in the past few decades but has its roots at the end of the nineteenth century. Maybe there were Rizalistas around even during Rizal's lifetime? Perhaps the Rizalistas are not crazy as they are thought to be after all. (6/21/88)



Statue in the main altar of the Iglesia Watawat ng Lahi, Lecheria Hill on the outskirts of Calamba, Laguna

Was Rizal Psychic?

1 de enero 1883. La Noche. Estoy muy triste yo. No sé qué vaga melancolía, indefinida soledad ahoga el alma, semejante a la profunda tristeza de las ciudades después de un tumultuoso júbilo, a una ciudad después de una felicísima unión. Soñé que imitando yo a un actor en una escena en que muere, sentí vivamente que me faltaba el aliento y perdía rápidamente las fuerzas. Después se me oscurecía la vista y densas tinieblas, como las de la nada, se apoderaban de mí: las angustias de la muerte. Quise gritar y pedir socorro a Antonio Paterno, sintiendo que iba a morir. Desperté sin fuerzas y sin aliento.

Despite the compulsory 12 units of Spanish we take up in college, few will be able to translate Jose Rizal's journal entry for January 1, 1883. Two of Rizal's biographers, Austin Coates and the late Leon Ma. Guerrero, have taken this text to prove that Rizal had psychic gifts. The translation follows:

Night. Mournful am I. I do not know what vague melancholy, what indefinable loneliness stifles the soul, similar to the profound sadness of cities after a tumultuous rejoicing, to a city after an exceedingly happy union. [Two nights ago, that is, December 30], I had a frightful nightmare when I almost died. I dreamed that imitating an actor in a scene in which he dies, I felt vividly that my breath was failing and I was rapidly losing strength. Then my vision became dim and dense darkness like that of nothingness overpowered me: the anguish of death. I wanted to shout and ask for help from Antonio Paterno, feeling that I was about to die. I awoke weak and breathless.

Checking with the Spanish edition of Rizal's *Diarios y Memorias* published by the Jose Rizal Centennial Commission in 1961, the line that dates the dream on December 30, 1883 is missing. However, the evidence is strong that Rizal's dream could have happened on that date, which 13 years later would be the exact day of his execution!

Rizal was always having these *Sueños bien tristes*, one in which he dreams about the death of his brother so vividly he wanted to cable home to check if it were true. In another dream, he writes:

I fancied that my sister Neneng [Saturnina] was with me on this trip. We reached some port and disembarked but, since there were no boats to take us, we had to wade ashore although we had been told there were many crocodiles and sharks about. When we touched land, the sandy soil, cultivated in some parts, was full of vipers, snakes, and serpents. Many boa constrictors were hanging along the way to the house where we were bound, some of them dead but others, although tied up, alive and menacing. We were walking along, my sister and I, she ahead and I following, showing each other the way. Sometimes,

we stumbled over dead snakes; the live ones tried to catch us but failed. But at the end of this row of snakes, the path narrowed and one snake remained, tied down it was true, but angry and threatening; it was in our way, with only the barest room to spare.

My sister was fortunate enough to get through, but in spite of every precaution, the snake caught me by my shirt and drew me toward itself. My strength failing, I sought something to which to cling, but found nothing. I felt I was being drawn closer and closer to the snake and that its tail was about to coil around me.

In the midst of my futile struggles, when death in the grip of loathsome coils was before my eyes, Pedro, the town carpenter, arrived and cut the snake from me. Saved from this danger we reached the house; I do not remember now whose it was.

Leon Ma. Guerrero writes that later in his life, Rizal would return to the Philippines with a sister and the friars, like the snakes in his dream, would coil around him and make sure that he was tried and shot. The snakes could have been the many hidden enemies Rizal was to encounter later in his life.

One day, someone should really go through all of Rizal's letters (in the six-volume *Epistolario Rizalino*) and all of his notes and diaries (in the multi-volume *Escritos de Rizal*) to gather all these paranormal experiences and try to fit them in with what really happened in Rizal's life. Austin Coates is even surprised that many incidents Rizal wrote about in his novels *Noli me Tángere* and *El Filibusterismo* eventually happened to him in real life. It is amazing that he could foresee all these things long before they happened. Some people think that Rizal's novels are autobiographical when they are actually prophetic in relation to his life. Austin Coates declares, "In some cases the fictional scene and the subsequent actual event are so close that in memory, one is apt to confuse the two. I can think of nothing else quite like this in literature."

Another avid (or should I say rabid) Rizal scholar was the late Guillermo Tolentino, National Artist for Sculpture, who had translated *Mi Último Adiós* into Italian and even transcribed it into the ancient Philippine script. Tolentino also wrote the Tagalog libretto for the opera *Noli me Tángere*, composed by Felipe Padilla de Leon. In an article on him as *spiritista* (see my book *Aguinaldo's Breakfast*), I had theorized that Tolentino made such good portraits of our national heroes because he talked to them from beyond the grave through a medium in the regular séances held in his home on Retiro Street, Sampaloc, Manila. In 1957, he spent P5,000 to publish a book, *Si Rizal*, which he had hoped would be used in U.P. for the Rizal courses as it was an anthology of selected Rizal writings translated into Tagalog. What makes this book interesting and different from the usual works on Rizal are the last chapters. In *Si*

Rizal sa Likod ng Libingan, Tolentino says that in June 1935, he consulted three mediums on three separate séances regarding articles in the newspapers about Rizal's retraction. He got the same answer from Rizal's spirit, which denied the authenticity of the supposed Rizal retraction. In Tagalog, Rizal was supposed to have said, "I don't know why my enemies persist in persecuting me even if I have long left the earth. I'm telling you that the retraction they say is mine is not mine, it's fake. You as an artist can easily create one of these. Why will I sign a retraction when I never turned my back to truth? I turned my back on darkness, ignorance, superstition and wrong faith..."

In the last chapter of the book "*Tinig ni Rizal Buhat sa Dako Pa Roon*," Tolentino writes about a séance he attended on January 25, 1948, in Manila with Doña Trinidad [Trining] Rizal, one of the national hero's surviving sisters, who was able to talk to her brother from beyond the grave through a medium, Felicidad Lopez. Excerpts from this séance:

In the name of our Lord I am allowed to greet you, especially my sister, with Peace from Heaven! My dear sister,

"Allow me in these moments, one who is without a body, to talk to you... allow me to speak in Tagalog because there is nothing more beautiful than to communicate with one's sister under the vast skies of the Philippines in the beautiful language of the Filipinos.

"Until now, since I left the earth there has never been any countryman who has truly loved, fell in love or will fall in love with the Tagalog language, which is part of his heritage and culture. Yes, people are being appointed in government, people who will make sure that Tagalog will be the premier or national language, although this is still nothing but empty words and promises. Go to the houses of the prominent and you will see how difficult it is for many Filipinos to speak the Tagalog language.

"Why is it that the people in power talk in a foreign tongue? These people your generation believed to be great are only pretending to love the Motherland. Even if they don't admit it, they are slaves by aping a language used by the colonial masters. There is nothing more valuable than your own language, that which was given to you by Heaven. I'm not saying that you shouldn't study foreign languages because one should, in life, keep on studying and if possible one should study forever. In truth, life is endless work, and if this is so, man must have knowledge which comes from research and constant study. You must realize that there are many kinds of knowledge. You must try your best to learn languages in order to understand different races and peoples. You must not learn a foreign language in order to promote it to the detriment of your own language.

"In terms of religion, it is sad that my countrymen for whom I gave my life in order to enlighten them are still slaves to the ignorance and superstition which comes from the uneducated and ignorant people who head the different

churches they cling to for support. These heads of churches who, instead of uniting people, sow dissent by claiming the exclusive right to truth.

"Why must you be misled by men who, being human, are prone to commit error? In truth, all men who walk the earth have imperfections. Remember the words of the Redeemer, 'The blind man who clings to another blind man will fall into the abyss,' Wake-up!...remember the sacrifice which I felt for all of you... my sister, listen to me. Remember that life is a never-ending struggle and he who does not struggle in this world is not worthy of a reward in Heaven. If you evade struggle, you are evading the rewards due your soul. Because of this, try to be courageous and build your confidence in order to surpass all these obstacles. Listen to me, my sister, and share my ideals, I will help you from this land of free souls. You need patience and perseverance because that which you encounter is not as great as that which the Lord had been through. Spread what we talked about to the people and try to get our conversation published."

Doña Trining then interjects: "But no one will believe and no one will read this."

Rizal says:

"If they ask me for more, I will continue and I will prove everything I have said to be true. Everything in the world is an illusion. I will help you with your work, believe in me and have faith in God because it is He who you should approach for help. I only hope that their ignorance will not be the reason for the people not to listen to the message you have just heard. Peace to you till the future.... farewell, your brother Jose Rizal."

It took almost ten years for this conversation to get into print. Today, the book of Tolentino, which he himself published in 1957, is gathering dust in his house. His widow, Paz Raymundo Vda. de Tolentino, hopes the National Library will accept these books as a donation and will send copies to all libraries in the Philippines. Whether it really was Rizal who spoke to Tolentino and Doña Trining Rizal, the words still ring with the nationalism and fervor that was Jose Rizal's. (11/2/86)

30

The Psychic in Rizal

I keep wondering why Jose Rizal, whether in statue or illustration is inseparable from his overcoat. This “overexposed” image based on his favorite studio photograph was popular as early as the late nineteenth century, but there are a number of forgotten photos taken in Juan Luna’s Paris studio that show a human side to our otherwise serious and one dimensional hero.

One amusing photo shows Felix Resurreccion Hidalgo, Juan Luna, Trinidad H. Pardo de Tavera, and Rizal seemingly playing “peek-a-boo” inside an empty picture frame. Luna’s pictures often served as compositions for his paintings, thus, a few of these photos had scenes with death as a theme, like *La Muerte de Cleopatra*. (The Death of Cleopatra). I presume that during those improvised pictorials, Rizal talked about both his dreams and his nightmares.

Some people may think that I am adding yet another entry to Rizal’s long list of achievements, but if one takes the trouble to go through the six volumes of Rizal’s correspondence published under the direction of Teodoro M. Kalaw of the National Library in the 1930s, one would find letters from friends and relatives informing Rizal that his dreams and/or prophecies had come true.



Tableau for *Muerte de Cleopatra*. Juan Luna on the bed and the seated figure with the Egyptian veil is Rizal. Paris, 1889.

Rizal's diary records a dream he had on December 30, 1883 in which he describes the feeling of a dying man—this, exactly 13 years before his execution! In a letter to Marcelo H. del Pilar from Brussels dated June 11, 1890, Rizal writes about his projects, his rush to finish the sequel to the *Noli me tângere*, and his use of the pseudonym *Laong Laan*. He writes:

... I am sad and in the midst of mournful presentiments but I don't believe all of them. When I was a boy I believed that I would not reach the age of 30, and I don't know why I used to think that way. Night after night, for the last two months, I have had dreams of friends and relatives who are now dead. Once, I even dreamed of descending into the depths of the earth where I was met by many people who were seated and dressed in white. They had white faces, were quiet and encircled with a white light. It was there that I saw two of my relatives, one already dead and the other still living. Even if I don't believe in these things and though my body is strong and I have no fear nor sickness of any kind, nevertheless, I prepare myself for death, arranging things I will leave behind and disposing myself for any eventuality. *Laong Laan* (Ever prepared), is my real name.

If the reactionary friars knew of these precognitive gifts then, it would have been easier for them to have Rizal executed. Rizal would probably have been burned at the stake as a friend of the devil. These days, though we may be tolerant of ESP, we remain scared of the Satanists. We love charismatic meetings and listen to fire-and-brimstone sermons from the TV evangelists. I wonder how Rizal would have been treated if he were alive today. Perhaps, he would make good money as a fortune teller?

Happy Halloween. (10/30/87)



Rizal and his barkada pose for posterity behind an empty picture frame. From left to Right: Felix Resurrecion Hidalgo, Juan Luna, Trinidad H. Pardo de Tavera and Rizal.

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The Writ that Could Have Changed History

I belong to a generation of Filipinos called the “Martial law babies” who, before 1986, had known no other president but Ferdinand Marcos. Come to think of it, I actually thought Marcos was a part of Malacañang’s furniture! Martial law memories came flooding back this week when I read the words “writ of habeas corpus” in our newspaper. Habeas corpus is imbedded in memory due to a Social Studies exam that forced me to define a concept I could not even spell correctly. I flunked that exam.

When habeas corpus first came into my consciousness, it had something to do with Ninoy Aquino, who was accused of subversion. It seems the wheel has turned full circle today because that same writ is being invoked by Aquino’s former jailer, Juan Ponce Enrile, who, during the martial law years, ignored it by issuing hundreds, if not thousands, of arrest-and-detention orders. Enrile, teary-eyed in “jail,” does give one a sense of hope—that there is such a thing as karma, or, should I say, divine retribution?

We can also look back to a petition for a writ of habeas corpus made on behalf of Jose Rizal in Singapore in 1896. Many people do not know that the National Library preserves original documents from the Supreme Court of Singapore that shed light on this last, vain attempt to save Rizal’s life. Singapore donated these papers to the Philippines during the Rizal centennial in 1961.

Rizal left Dapitan for Barcelona in July, 1896, ending over three years of exile. His application to serve in the Spanish army in Cuba had been approved, and he even carried letters of recommendation from no less than Spanish Governor-General Ramon Blanco himself. En route to Spain, Rizal was called to the captain’s cabin, where he was informed that he was implicated in a revolution that had broken out in Manila in August. Placed under arrest, Rizal was imprisoned in Montjuich Castle upon arrival in Barcelona. Since Rizal was to stand trial in Manila, he was taken as a prisoner on board a chartered ship carrying Spanish soldiers to the Philippines. However, he was free to roam about the vessel when it was already in the high seas. He was prohibited from disembarking at any port where they stopped for fuel and supplies. To make sure he did not escape, he was thrown behind bars hours before the ship reached port. Twice, he was handcuffed. Sixteen hours before docking at

Singapore, the last fuel stop before Manila, Rizal was again thrown behind bars. Here, a writ was requested for him.

From London, Antonio Maria Regidor sent two telegrams to common friends in Singapore requesting them to petition the Singapore court to issue a writ of habeas corpus, thus, allowing Rizal to disembark and walk to liberty. However, these Filipinos were fearful of Spanish reprisal on their relatives in the Philippines, so they hired English lawyers to do it for them. The telegrams state:

Rizal returns as a prisoner on board that steamer *Colón*, which will arrive there [Singapore] shortly. He holds letters from [Governor-General] Blanco denying charges against him. The Spanish Constitution prohibits imprisonment without order of a judge. *Colón* when anchored in English territory [becomes subject to English laws thus, these laws] authorize anybody to demand liberty of Rizal. Instruct Solicitor telling him that Sir Edward Clarke, Ex-Solicitor-General, having been consulted advises an application for a writ of habeas corpus. Make affidavit stating [Rizal's] imprisonment on vessel [without] any judicial sentence. On grounds of urgency claim writ absolute in first instance, returnable immediately on service. Address writ to Captain Ugarte and all officers or any officer-in-charge of *Colón* and serve immediately when ship arrives. Case of *León XIII* there [in Singapore] in 1882 fully supports form and issue of Writ. Funds provided [through] Chartered Bank. Telegraph Valdez. London

In 1882, issuance of a writ allowed British subjects held prisoner on the ship *León XIII* to disembark in Singapore. In the opinion of a prominent English legal mind, Rizal could also be issued a writ on the basis of this precedent.

Unfortunately, the chief justice of Singapore rejected the application for a writ after reviewing the case overnight because Rizal was a Spanish subject on board a Spanish ship. Even if a writ were issued, the Spanish consul could protest and produce a document proving Rizal was, indeed, a dangerous prisoner awaiting trial in Manila. Rizal was shipped home to face a kangaroo court that sentenced him to death.

Historians will say it is useless to think of what would have happened had the writ been issued for Rizal by the Singapore Supreme Court. Of course, the tide of history could have changed course. Sometimes, it pays not to be interested in what happened but in what did *not* happen. It is amusing to think that had Rizal served in Cuba, then he would have been an *indio* in the Spanish Army that was trying to crush the Cuban war of independence. Perhaps, Rizal would not be the national hero today. (3/4/90)

Rizal's New Calamba in Sabah

Last week, I read some news items suggesting that the Philippines should drop her claim on Sabah (again?) in order to ease the tension with neighboring claimant Malaysia.

It amuses me to think that Jose Rizal could have made it easy for us to claim the island today had he succeeded in establishing a Filipino colony there in 1892.

You see, the Rizals were not really landowners. They were tenants of the Dominicans who owned most of the land in Calamba. According to the Rizals (the Dominicans have their own version of the story), the tenants started to complain about the rent increases that did not consider whether the harvest for that season was good or not. Also, the Dominicans never issued receipts for the rent collected. The Calambeños complained to the government, but when nothing happened, they threatened to stop paying rent. The Dominicans countered by declaring the lands vacant, and invited non-Calambeños to settle in Calamba.

Rizal was not a radical man, but in 1891, he became a spokesman for these tenants whom he advised to trust in the justice and goodness of Mother Spain. The tenants did just that, and the Spanish governor-general, Valeriano Weyler (who later became notorious as the Butcher of Cuba), sent soldiers to bodily evict the hardheaded tenants from Calamba. To make matters worse, people in the neighboring towns were warned against giving shelter to the dispossessed Calambeños. The Rizals had to transport their belongings, including one entire house, by casco via the Pasig River to Binondo. It was a major upheaval for the people of Calamba and also for Rizal, who became a marked man not only for his anti-clerical novel, *Noli me Tángere*, but also for being in the center of a major agrarian dispute.

Would Rizal have become a hero if his family and friends were not thrown out of Calamba by the Spaniards? Was Rizal's heroism motivated by his personal circumstances? It will take more than one column to answer these questions, but Rizal felt personally responsible for the eviction of the Calamba people that he tried his best to think of schemes to put them back on their feet. Then in Hong Kong, in 1892, he thought: Why not bring them to Sabah?

In one of his trips, Rizal had befriended an Englishman, William Pryer, who was the first resident and acknowledged founder of Sandakan, at the time the capital of North Borneo (now Sabah). Rizal made a trip to

Sandakan, looked him up, and was received quite well by British colonial officials who were anxious to have a rice-growing settlement in Sandakan to augment its meager produce. Rizal was promised 5,000 acres of rent-free land for the first three years—if the Filipino colony agreed to plant rice.

Ecstatic at this development, Rizal wrote to the Spanish governor-general requesting a change in citizenship for the persecuted Calamba families and for their safe, unhampered passage. One of Rizal's sisters who was living in exile wrote an aunt in Manila that Rizal was in Sandakan and that the children would be growing up there, "*Ang mga maliliit natin ay magiging taga-Borneo na.*"

Spain was losing her colonies in South America and the Philippines was turning out to be a source of trouble itself. Nevertheless, the Spanish governor-general rejected Rizal's requests, knowing that a Filipino colony in Sandakan would be an embarrassment to the Spanish colonial administration. It would show the world that Filipinos wanted to leave their own country! Rizal was coaxed into shelving this scheme. He travelled back to the Philippines and was promptly deported to Dapitan.

It was later discovered that the British official who promised Rizal easy terms in Sandakan could not speak for the British North Borneo Company. Thus, ended Rizal's Utopian dream to set up a paradise, a New Calamba in Sabah. (4/18/89)

